

News Writing

District Meet • 2026



You are a reporter for the **Leaguetown Press**, the student newspaper of Leaguetown High School.

From the given information, write a **news story** as you would for the high school newspaper. You may use statements attributed to individuals as **direct or indirect quotes**. You may not change the meaning of a statement. You have **45 minutes**.

Do not write your name or the name of your school on this sheet or your entry. **Put your number on your paper.**

Leaguetown High School has 4,011 students enrolled in grades 9-12. Principal Sam Lyman suspended junior Kate Harper for three days last fall after she posted three memes on Instagram using photos of Lyman. One meme depicted Lyman as an anime character. Another showed him in a scene from the TV show “Stranger Things,” and another showed Lyman in a scene from Minecraft. The memes appeared on Harper’s personal account in three separate posts on three separate dates.

According to the student code of conduct, students are prohibited from sharing photos that aim to “demean, embarrass or discredit” students and staff. It also mandates that students follow a philosophy called the “Leopard Law,” which outlines the district’s expectations for respecting students, staff and facilities in the district.

After serving her suspension, Harper hired an attorney from the First Amendment Foundation who began working with her to sue the school district, claiming the suspension violated her First Amendment rights. A trial is scheduled to begin in August. In the meantime, the district hired a third party to send a survey to parents and students asking for feedback on the student code of conduct.

The school board will discuss the survey results at its March 26 meeting. You are writing for the issue of the press to be distributed March 23.

■ KATE HARPER, junior

“Mr. Lyman is just so serious all the time. It’s not like he did anything to me. I wasn’t trying to hurt him or anyone else by posting the images. It was just satire. I was trying to lightly poke fun at his personality a little bit, but he took major offense to it.

“I got called down to Lyman’s office, and he lectured me about respect and the Leopard Law. Then he called my mom and told her I was getting suspended. He wrote up a report that said I violated the student code of conduct. I signed it and left. I was in tears leaving his office, but the more I thought about it, the angrier I got. The school has no right to say what goes on my personal social media accounts. That’s my business. That night, my parents helped me find an attorney.

“Students have been making fun of their teachers, administrators and their school since the beginning of time. I didn’t deserve to be suspended for making some memes. The suspension should be wiped off my record, and I expect to see some major changes to school policy after we go through this process. But this lawsuit isn’t about me and my punishment. A school shouldn’t get to decide what students are allowed to say and what we aren’t allowed to say on our own time.”

■ **SAM LYMAN, principal**

“Our student code of conduct clearly prohibits students from posting and sharing photos or videos making fun of staff or other students. It also prohibits students from sharing any social media post that violates the Leopard Law. Students learn the Leopard Law from the time they become a student at this school. It’s a term that represents respect and kindness for each individual in our community. We expect our students to follow it, even when it comes to online behavior. They sign off on these rules when they receive the code of conduct, so this is nothing new.

“You have to have some pretty thick skin to be a high school administrator, but I’m also obliged to follow the code of conduct as it’s written. The fact is, a student was harrassing someone from the school community online. I’m going to protect our other staff and our students from online harassment, no matter what. It just so happens that the person being harassed was me.”

■ **MATTHEW SANTOS, First Amendment Foundation attorney**

“They gave Kate the same punishment they give students who fight at school. It’s the punishment for schoolyard bullies, students who cheat on tests and students who cause major disruptions to the school day. Kate sat alone in her private home and quietly posted pictures online. According to the school, she deserved the same punishment as all those other students. This was a clear violation of her rights, and we expect the judge to agree with us when we go to trial this summer. The Leopard Law is a cute little phrase, but it does not apply in a court of law. It’s problematic in how subjective it is. These school districts need to respect the First Amendment, even if it hurts their feelings.”

■ **ANNABETH SCHOTT, sophomore**

“I remember seeing the picture online of Mr. Lyman smiling with the Demogorgon from ‘Stranger Things.’ I kind of smiled, but honestly, it was pretty silly. I didn’t think much of it and kept on scrolling. When I found out they suspended Kate for posting the photos, my jaw hit the floor. I say stupid things in our soccer team group chat, making fun of our coaches all the time. Am I going to get suspended for that, too? This whole situation has me wondering if I should delete my accounts or block certain people from seeing what I post.”

■ **ADDITIONAL INFORMATION**

A 2021 U.S. Supreme Court decision, *Mahanoy Area School District v. B.L.*, stated that schools cannot punish students for speech or expression that happens outside the school day away from school grounds as long as that expression does not disrupt the school learning environment.

DO NOT DISTRIBUTE TO STUDENTS BEFORE OR DURING THE CONTEST!

District Meet • 2026 News Writing Contest Tips and Sample Story

Contest Director: Give one copy to each judge to use during judging. Also, staple one copy of the contest and one copy of the contest tips to each student's returned entry. The purpose of the tips is to provide immediate feedback to students. However, it is not meant to replace written comments from the judges.

1. Open with the most timely lead, given the current circumstances, probably the future event or events. In this instance, the story will be published before the school board discusses survey results about the student code of conduct.

Students could see changes to the student code of conduct after the school board reviews community survey results at its March 26 meeting.

The district commissioned the survey after junior Kate Harper sued the district for violating her First Amendment rights when they suspended her for posting memes on Instagram depicting Principal Sam Lyman. The trial is set for August.

2. Use direct quotes and use those quotes early in the story. Start with the most important interview to the story. After you introduce quotes, use the transition/quote formula. Be sure you attribute the quote. An attribution should be: subject of attribution followed by the verb of attribution ("Harper said," not "said Harper.") Avoid putting two or more quotes from different people together without placing a transition between them (stacking quotes). Also, make sure transitions provide information to help the story flow, and that the quote does not repeat information revealed in the transition.

transition

Harper posted the three images from her home. One showed Lyman as an anime character, and others showed Lyman in scenes from "Stranger Things" and the video game Minecraft.

direct quote

"Students have been making fun of their teachers, administrators and their school since the beginning of time," Harper said. "I didn't deserve to be suspended for making some memes."

transition

After Lyman called her down to the front office and notified her she was being suspended, Harper said she left the office in tears.

direct quote

"The more I thought about it, the angrier I got," she said. "The school has no right to say what goes on my personal social media accounts. That's my business. That night, my parents helped me find an attorney."

3. Use third person. Don't say "our students" or "our principal" or "Some of our students." Also, do not editorialize. For instance, you should not say "This idea probably won't work..." or "The district should ..." without attributing that quote to someone. These statements are personal opinions and cannot be made in a news story.

4. Note how in the earlier example of transition/quote, each quote is its own paragraph. Journalistic writing consists mostly of one- and two-sentence paragraphs.

5. End with a strong quote that wraps up the story.

transition

Harper said she expects to see some major changes to school policy by the time her case goes to trial in August.

direct quote

"This lawsuit isn't about me and my punishment," she said. "A school shouldn't get to decide what students are allowed to say and what we aren't allowed to say on our own time."

SAMPLE STORY

Students could see changes to the student code of conduct after the school board reviews community survey results at its March 26 meeting.

The district commissioned the survey after junior Kate Harper sued the district for violating her First Amendment rights when they suspended her for posting memes on Instagram depicting Principal Sam Lyman. The trial is set for August.

“I wasn’t trying to hurt him or anyone else by posting the images,” Harper said. “I was trying to lightly poke fun at his personality a little bit, but he took major offense to it.”

Harper posted the three images from her home. One showed Lyman as an anime character, and others showed Lyman in scenes from “Stranger Things” and the video game Minecraft.

“Students have been making fun of their teachers, administrators and their school since the beginning of time,” Harper said. “I didn’t deserve to be suspended for making some memes.”

After Lyman called her down to the front office and notified her she was being suspended, Harper said she left the office in tears.

“The more I thought about it, the angrier I got,” she said. “The school has no right to say what goes on my personal social media accounts. That’s my business. That night, my parents helped me find an attorney.”

They found Matthew Santos from the First Amendment Foundation, who said the suspension was a clear violation of Harper’s rights.

“They gave Kate the same punishment they give students who fight at school,” he said. “It’s the punishment for schoolyard bullies, students who cheat on tests and students who cause major disruptions to the school day. Kate sat alone in her private home and quietly posted pictures online.”

But Lyman said the student code of conduct is clear about showing respect to students and staff — even online.

“You have to have some pretty thick skin to be a high school administrator, but I’m also obliged to follow the code of conduct as it’s written,” Lyman said. “The fact is, a student was harassing someone from the school community online. I’m going to protect our other staff and our students from online harassment, no matter what. It just so happens that the person being harassed was me.”

The code of conduct includes wording about what the district calls the “Leopard Law,” which outlines the expectation of showing respect to students, staff and facilities in the district. But a 2021 U.S. Supreme Court case states that what students post online outside the school day is out of bounds for school discipline, unless it disrupts the school day.

“The Leopard Law is a cute little phrase, but it does not apply in a court of law,” Santos said. “It’s problematic in how subjective it is. These school districts need to respect the First Amendment, even if it hurts their feelings.”

Harper said she expects to see some major changes to school policy by the time her case goes to trial in August.

“This lawsuit isn’t about me and my punishment,” she said. “A school shouldn’t get to decide what students are allowed to say and what we aren’t allowed to say on our own time.”